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A fear of using regular flights following the pandemic led a new class of passengers to book air charters

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The bespoke menu served aboard several charter flights includes exotic dishes prepared by a sous chef

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A comfortable seat is often accompanied by the finest pillows, bedsheets and linen from international brands



and special Greek linen to personalised crockery, cushions and sleepwear. Moreover, the aircraft are put through a multi-stage sanitisation check for the passenger's safety. The on-ground concierge also offers any assistance required by passengers in finding conveyance or hotel bookings.

From all your business needs to leisure requirements, charter services take care of everything with an extra layer of luxury. However, all these come at a cost. Unlike industrialists like Ratan Tata (Dassault Falcon 2000), Mukesh Ambani (Boeing Business Jet) and Adar Poonwalla (Airbus A320), it may not be feasible for many others to own or maintain a private jet. Especially when their prices range from \$4.95 million to \$170 million for aircraft like the Embraer Phenom 100 and the Boeing 767-33A ER, respectively.

And this is where chartering an aircraft makes sense. For instance, Blade India, a JV between Blade US and Hunch Ventures—that specialises in helicopter charters—charges ₹1 lakh per hour

on average. You are also required to pay for the return leg of the journey. The final fare is calculated based on the aircraft type, distance covered, the time taken and landing and parking charges. For example, the cost of a Delhi-Goa-Delhi and Mumbai-Delhi-Mumbai round trip currently works out to ₹18-25 lakh and ₹17-24 lakh, respectively, while international charters on routes like Delhi-Dubai-Delhi and Mumbai-Male-Mumbai could cost between ₹35-50 lakh and ₹38-54 lakh, respectively, for a same-day round trip.

RIISING DEMAND

So, what is spurring this trend? The reason lies in the changes brought on by Covid-19. "When the first wave struck, a lot of people had their families stuck in different cities. They had this fear of using passenger flights because there wasn't much clarity. So, they hired charters," informs Kanika Tekriwal, CEO of JetSetGo, India's first charter service aggregator.

Once the virus began to recede